

The Dragon King and the Jellyfish

This tale is inspired
by a story from Japan.

According to legend, if you dive deep into the sea off the coast of Japan, you might just catch a glimpse of the most magnificent palace.

It belongs to Ryujin, the Dragon King, whose mouth is so big he can swallow whales in a single gulp, and crush a ship between his jaws. His powers are so huge that he controls the mighty tides with just two beautiful jewels—one to call the seas in, and another to send them away.

Every day, the Dragon King roams around his underwater palace.

Built entirely from coral, the palace spirals up through forty floors. There are mesmerizing gardens and a grand hall for each of the seasons.

The autumn hall is filled with maple trees. The ceilings hang heavy with apple-laden branches and the smells of maple, damp leaves, and bonfires.

The spring hall is filled with blossom trees. Butterflies flutter around and hover over a carpet of petals.

The winter hall is tiled with a million glittering crystals. Tiny fish,

seahorses, turtles, and dolphins, fly down ice slides, landing in soft snow.

Crickets chirp in the summer hall, singing along, as starfish skip over lavender gardens and rest in rose beds.

One day, as the Dragon King admired his gardens, he came across a thrashing swordfish caught in coral.

Ryujin tried to set it free, but as he did, the swordfish accidentally scratched his throat—the only place he isn't covered in impenetrable scales.

Worried about the wound, the Dragon King summoned his closest advisors.

"Find the liver of a monkey," one of his advisors said, "rub it on the wound and it will heal immediately."

Ryujin summoned a jellyfish to him (in those days a jellyfish looked more like a turtle, with four legs and a hard shell).